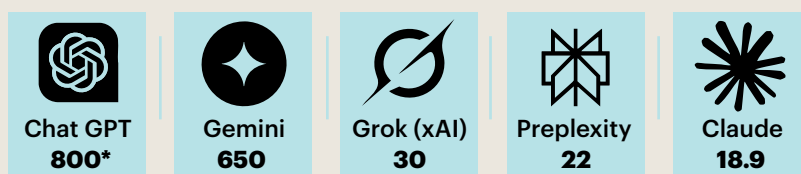


## AI USERS

ChatGPT is the most widely used AI engine in India



\*AVERAGE WEEKLY USERS IN MILLION; OTHERS ARE APPROX MONTHLY USER NUMBERS **NOTE** THESE ARE GLOBAL USER NUMBERS; INDIA USER BASE IS APPROX. 10-12% OF THIS. **SOURCE** COMPANIES/DEMANDSAGE

ILLUSTRATION BY RAJ VERMA

30 | dation models as a strategic fallback, not a walled alternative,” says Bal.

Industry leaders echo this pragmatism. Nikhil Malhotra, Chief Innovation Officer at Tech Mahindra, calls India’s approach “as a build-versus-buy balance, complemented by efficiency pathways.” Smaller, distilled models, trained with the right data and context, can perform effectively, he says. Examples include AI models fine-tuned for specific tasks like farming advice or customer support in local languages.

In a conversation with *BT* at the WEF, James Manyika, Senior Vice President of Google Alphabet, talked about how India is transitioning into a premier hub for high-impact AI research. From scaling life-saving diabetic screenings to deploying monsoon models to about 38 million farmers, these initiatives showcase India’s ability to effectively apply AI and solve pressing challenges, he said.

There is consensus in government and industry that AI in India is crossing a threshold. “India is approaching an inflection point where AI will no longer be a frontier technology but a foundational capability for every sector,” says Puneet Chandok, President of Microsoft India and South Asia.

Microsoft’s \$17.5 billion investment in India’s Cloud and AI backbone reflects that belief. The goal, says Chandok, “is not only to build advanced models

but also to diffuse intelligence across the economy.” Into hospitals, classrooms, factories, farms and more.

Sectors with “population-scale impact,” says Singh, are expected to drive much of the projected \$1.7 trillion AI economy, prioritising areas like healthcare, agriculture, education, climate and sustainability, financial services and learning disabilities.

### START-UPS PUSH THE ENVELOPE

If the state provides AI scaffolding, start-ups supply the velocity. Under the India AI Mission, more than 40 proposals for foundational and specialised models, spanning education, materials science, multimodal AI, and language systems, have been filed. Some projects reportedly range from two billion to hundreds of billions of parameters, including a large voice-enabled model optimised for Indian languages.

Sarvam AI, founded in 2023, is focused on building LLMs. In April 2025, it was shortlisted to develop India’s indigenous foundational model under the India AI Mission.

Google-backed BharatGPT, India’s Sovereign LLM developed by CoRover.ai, has been designed specifically for understanding diverse Indian languages and cultural nuances for text, voice, and video interactions. HDFC Bank is an investor in CoRover.ai.

AI start-ups are working across segments. For ex-